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Homophobic Twitter Hashtags, Straight Masculinity, and Networks of Queer Disavowal

BONNIE RUBERG

#nohomo on Twitter

The phrase “no homo” and its corresponding hashtag “#nohomo” appear approximately five thousand times a day on Twitter.¹ Most often placed at the end of tweets, #nohomo is ostensibly used to signify that the content preceding it should not be interpreted as homoerotic or “gay.” However, in this essay I argue that the actual meanings of #nohomo, while indeed homophobic, are more nuanced and telling than they may at first appear. In fact, #nohomo functions as a tool for performing and self-policing straight masculinity. In a social media environment, the hashtag mediates utterances that are implicitly associated with “homoness.” These utterances fall into three main categories: (1) expressions of male-male intimacy, (2) the declaration of feelings, and (3) an interest in self-presentation and the body. In this way, #nohomo represents an attempt to distance the user from associations with both queerness and femininity. At the same time, it stands as evidence of the anxieties of cisgender male heterosexuality as it is performed in social media spaces and links #nohomo tweeters through a network of queer disavowal.

While many other hashtags on social media platforms trend and then fade away, entering popular use for a brief period during a particular cultural or political moment, #nohomo has appeared with notable consistency throughout Twitter’s history. In this sense, the phrase

is an endemic fixture of the site's discursive landscape. This is also true of a number of other homophobic terms and phrases used on Twitter (e.g., "so gay"), as well as racist, sexist, transphobic, and ableist expressions of hate speech. However, #nohomo stands out among these terms precisely because it is, first and foremost, a hashtag: a unique unit of communication that emerged from within the Twitter-sphere. As such, it functions socially and semantically in ways that distinguish it from homophobic speech uttered offline and in other digital environments. Even when #nohomo appears on Twitter in non-hashtag form—as "no homo" or "nohomo"—the phrase remains fundamentally linked to the networked nature of meaning-making that the hashtag represents. #nohomo embodies the place where cultural anxieties about difference meet computer-mediated communication. At a moment when the linguistic unit of the hashtag is moving from Twitter into mainstream discourse, and when online harassment campaigns against marginalized subjects have reached new peaks of vitriol, the boundaries between oppressive language online and offline are blurring.² Deconstructing the social and rhetorical functions of #nohomo offers a valuable opportunity to better understand the complex relationship between language and identity as it both manifests in and emerges from digital spaces.

The Uses of #nohomo

#nohomo, and its spoken incarnation, "no homo," may initially seem dismissible as mere flip (albeit offensive) turns of phrase. To the contrary, my research has shown that the hashtag and its iterations serve as shorthand for a surprisingly intricate, largely unspoken, and widely held set of heteronormative beliefs about what it means to express oneself—and, indeed, to enact oneself—as a gendered and sexual subject on the internet. In particular, I contend that #nohomo most commonly performs a self-policing of cisgender, male heterosexuality. More explicitly than other forms of homophobic speech, #nohomo functions less as a direct expression of discrimination and more as a tool for making oneself an acceptable subject within a system of straight masculinity. In fact, rather than overt homoeroticism, the central concerns of #nohomo tweets are intimacy, affect, and the bodies of seemingly cisgender male users. Often the hashtag is deployed to mediate affectionate communication between such users as well as to render "safe" expressions of male-male fandom. Another trend that I have identified is the link between #nohomo tweets and male users' expressions of emotions, both positive and negative.

Tweets from male users about body care and clothing are also prominent fixtures within the landscape of #nohomo usage; in these cases, the hashtag appears to reflect an attempt on the part of speakers to distance themselves from associations with femininity.

Together, these patterns suggest a larger picture around #nohomo usage. By insisting on what is not “homo,” #nohomo signposts an otherwise implicit network of what is imagined as “homo,” giving definition to queerness as seen through the anxieties of straight masculinity. By their nature, hashtags create networks. Rather than establishing a network of shared interests, political goals, or community (e.g., #BlackLivesMatter, #ItGetsBetter), however, #nohomo creates a *network of disavowal*. A network of disavowal is one in which subjects are, ironically, connected through their attempts to distance themselves from connection. By using the hashtag to reject association with “homo-ness,” #nohomo users in fact build a web of links that associates them with others who have also deployed #nohomo. Through this network, which speaks to a set of anxieties about the precariousness of heteronormativity in online spaces, the prevalence of #nohomo brings a queer valence to Twitter and digital modes of communication more broadly. In addition to its ties to historically feminine-coded genres of writing, such as the diary, platforms like Twitter, designed to facilitate interpersonal connection, seem to raise concerns about whether the structures of social media may themselves be “homo.” The widespread use of #nohomo stands as evidence that homophobic discourse thrives in digital spaces, yet it also suggests that the structures of computer-mediated expression might themselves be implicitly understood by some users as queer.

Methodologies

This project stands at the intersection of big data, cultural analysis, and close reading. It emerges from a collaboration between humanists like myself, social scientists, and data engineers. Starting in 2012, UC Berkeley’s Color of New Media collective began work on a software tool that scrapes and parses content from Twitter associated with specific phrases. For the present study, we pulled tweets containing “#nohomo,” “nohomo” or “no homo.” These tweets were collected over designated periods in 2013, 2014, and 2015. The resulting data set was processed through the tool’s topic modeling algorithm, which generated “constellations,” or common clusters in usage patterns, across the data set. Importantly, this algorithmic output was not the conclusion of my re-

search but the starting point. By identifying patterns in the archive, which consisted of tens of thousands of tweets, the tool pointed me to toward key areas of interest and allowed me to perform a critique of a body of text that would otherwise be too vast for the “naked eye.”³ Conceptually, this work draws from notions of language, culture, power, and identity formation articulated by Judith Butler and Michel Foucault, as well as “speech act” theory, while adapting and expanding these notions for the digital context.⁴ There are also limitations to these methodologies. Because Twitter does not collect information regarding users’ racial and ethnic identities, it is difficult to comment on the role that race plays in #nohomo usage without making problematic assumptions. Language, nationality, and geography also present challenges. Even users’ gender and sexual identity, central concerns in the discussion below, are not tracked by Twitter. This means that, by necessity, my points regarding correlations between gender, sexuality, and #nohomo usage are less concerned with “realness”—that is, definitively categorizing who #nohomo users “really” are—and more concerned with the equally important issue of performances of identity, such as the performance of straight, cisgender masculinity. In place of offering definitive answers, this work uses the #nohomo hashtag as a window onto the anxieties and beliefs that drive discrimination against LGBTQ subjects and shape normative notions of sexual and gender identity, both online and off.

“No Homo” and #nohomo: A History

Though the phrase “no homo” has become most prominent in its widespread use on social media platforms, particularly Twitter, it originates offline in African American vernacular culture. “No homo” was originally coined in East Harlem in the 1990s, but it entered more mainstream circulation through hip-hop music, where it was introduced by rapper Cam’ron in the early 2000’s and popularized by Lil Wayne—as in the 2009 single “Run This Town,” where Wayne raps, “It’s crazy how you go from being Joe Blow, to everybody on your dick, no homo” (Weiner 2009). Here, in these early examples of the phrase’s appearance in popular culture, the link between homoeroticism (“everybody on your dick”) and the supposedly clarifying function of “no homo” (translated roughly to “but I don’t mean that in a gay way”) is clear. In response to claims that hip-hop culture has traditionally discriminated against LGBTQ people, evidenced by homophobic remarks like “no homo” through which rap artists have distanced themselves from the figure of the “down low

brother,” some commentators have argued that “no homo” has actually allowed hip-hop to become a “gayer place.” “No homo,” so this thinking goes, creates the opportunity for straight male rappers to test the boundaries of heteronormativity by offering them the opportunity to speak and subsequently negate the “gayness” of their lyrics (Catucci 2009). This seeming contradiction, within which “no homo” might simultaneously encapsulate a system of cultural homophobia and make space for the expression of queerness, stands as a backdrop to the social functions of “no homo.”

The popularization of “no homo” in hip-hop, and subsequently mainstream, parlance coincided with the marked rise in Twitter usage recorded between 2007 and 2008. The translation of the phrase from primarily a spoken utterance to a social media fixture took place at a crucial moment in the popularization of the social media platform, when the average number of tweets per day skyrocketed 6,000 percent (Beaumont 2010). Hashtags are emergent units of communication: users invented and implemented them, and then Twitter integrated them into the site’s official system. In this moment of coevolution, “no homo” was already uniquely suited to the hashtag format. Similarly, to the way that a hashtag is placed at the end of a tweet, the verbal phrase “no homo” follows a speaker’s statement, clarifying and coloring its content and linking it within a network of references. Already functioning in spoken language as a kind of proto-hashtag, “no homo” transitioned and translated easily into #nohomo. When it did, the phrase moved beyond African American vernacular speech and was adopted by Twitter’s broader and predominantly white user base.⁵ In this sense, “no homo” reflects the well-documented phenomenon by which rhetorical innovations from Black culture are co-opted and decontextualized. #nohomo in particular demonstrates the role that digital media can play in the appropriation of Black culture (Clifton 2015). In this case, Twitter functioned as the primary locus and an amplifier of this cooptation.

Both “no homo,” as a phrase used in conversation, and #nohomo, its digital incarnation, claim to disavow the homoerotic implications of the utterance that immediately precedes it. They represent an attempt to nullify the queerness of statements that are seen as having homoerotic connotations or overtones. However, on Twitter, #nohomo is employed in this way surprisingly rarely; tweets with overtly homoerotic content number among the least common in identifiable genres of #nohomo tweets. In fact, the hashtag #nohomo has taken on much more nuanced social and rhetorical functions than the phrase “no homo.” Because the

hashtag is often appended to tweets that do not contain explicitly homoerotic content, #nohomo itself often “queers” tweets at the same time that it purports to negate queerness. This is because, by nature, the presence of #nohomo suggests that a tweet’s content might be interpreted as “homo.” In presenting my research on #nohomo, I have often encountered audiences’ expectation that the hashtag is used ironically or humorously. This may be true for the spoken “no homo,” but the Twitter data set suggests that, though #nohomo often appears in tweets with a jocular tone, it is almost always used in earnest. Much as Sarah Banet-Weiser and Kate M. Miltner have argued about hashtags in their work on #MasculinitySoFragile, #nohomo speaks in real and meaningful ways to the functions through which identity is constructed and deconstructed on Twitter (Banet-Weiser and Miltner 2016). In what follows, I have grouped the usage patterns of #nohomo into three primary categories: male-male intimacy, body care, and affect. Together they demonstrate how straight masculinity defines itself through queer disavowal and how the “homo” is imagined as a danger that lurks within the very systems of social media.

Male-Male Intimacy, Communication, and Fandom

Among the most frequent uses of #nohomo is the mediation of intimacy and affection between two or more male Twitter users—as well as between an individual male user and another man, such as a movie star or sports figure, for whom the user is expressing admiration. It is common to see #nohomo appear in tweets that proclaim sentiments of straight male friendship, or what might be termed “bro-ship.” Sometimes these tweets directly state warm feelings; at other times they simply imply caring and connection by enacting friendliness. Here are two examples of this genre of #nohomo tweets⁶:

@twitterfriend1 I love you, bro #nohomo

Hey dude, happy birthday @twitterfriend2 #nohomo

In the first tweet, the speaker is using #nohomo to assure the friend whom he is addressing that his “love” is safe and normatively acceptable—in other words, heterosexual. In the second tweet, the affection between the users is implied, yet the speaker still includes the #nohomo hashtag. The utterance “happy birthday” presumably express-

es caring and therefore is also associated with an intimacy that could be perceived as “homo.” Such instances, in which #nohomo is deployed to disavow even the most basic sentiments of male-male friendship, suggest that friendliness between heterosexual men is imagined by some users to represent a potential site of queer slippage. While constructs of bro-ship allow for expressions of male-male closeness (e.g., “I love you bro”), they also produce anxiety between users who must always also be working to uphold heterosexual masculinity. Bro-ship is therefore formulated as straight yet queer-adjacent, and it must be carefully monitored and mediated in order to ward off the threat of queerness.

Importantly, in the social media context, #nohomo’s function as a safeguard against queerness in male-male friendships is fundamentally linked to the communicative structures of Twitter. Taken as a total data set, #nohomo tweets on average contain a higher number of @-mentions and @-replies than random samplings of tweets. Roughly speaking, #nohomo tweets are approximately one and a half times more likely to contain @-mentions and @-replies than tweets that do not contain #nohomo. @-mentions and @-replies are the tools through which users directly link their tweets to other users. Within the formal structures of Twitter, @-mentions and @-replies both enact and embody connections between individuals. If we understand intimacy as characterized in part through interpersonal closeness and attachment, @-mentions and @-replies are the formal units of intimacy on Twitter. The fact that #nohomo tweets contain, on average, a higher percentage of these units suggests that structured connections through @-mentions and @-replies have themselves become associated, whether directly or indirectly, with the anxieties of heterosexual male sociability. These mentions and replies literalize the type of intimacy that #nohomo polices. Through the structure of links, they create ties between users’ Twitter accounts that may themselves implicitly be associated with homo-ness.

Related to #nohomo’s function in mediating male-male friendships is the use of the hashtag in tweets in which male users express their appreciation for male celebrities, such as movie stars, musicians, and, above all, athletes. These tweets usually perform fandom either through specific references to a celebrity’s accomplishments or through a general proclamation of positive sentiment. Tweets of this sort often look like this:

LeBron James is a basketball god. #nohomo

Ok, I'm actually really liking this Justin Bieber album. #nohomo

Michael Phelps dominated today. That dude has muscles like WHAT. #nohomo

The use of #nohomo in tweets such as these suggests that male-male fandom, in the eyes of heterosexual masculinity, stands in complicated relation to “homo-ness.” As the first tweet demonstrates, the prevalence of #nohomo in these utterances implies a concern that men’s admiration of other men will be presumed queer, even when these tweets contain no explicitly homoerotic content. It seems that the mere expression of positive feeling suggests a queer intimacy that must be neutralized. The second tweet represents another prominent and related genre of tweet. Here, the celebrity or material for which the straight male user is expressing appreciation is imagined to be associated with queerness (i.e., liking Justin Bieber is “homo”). In the third tweet, the user expresses admiration for the body of a male celebrity. Whereas the first tweet reflects the rigidity of heterosexual masculinity, which renders unacceptable appreciation for other men, the second and third tweets do suggest, as discussed above, that #nohomo allows users to push the boundaries of their straight male identities. By amending their statements with #nohomo, they are able to admit to liking “queer” music and to appreciate male bodies while returning to their positions as normative heterosexual subjects. In such moments, #nohomo makes queer-coded expression possible while working to uphold a hegemonic system.

Among the perceived traits of queerness that #nohomo suggests is the belief that same-sex friendship, intimacy, fandom, and even basic appreciation can constitute “homo-ness.” Notably, as the prevalence of @-mentions and @-replies in this data set indicates, this intimacy also extends to the structures of interpersonal communication in digital spaces; these structures themselves create connections that are too close for straight male comfort. The hashtag #nohomo makes these beliefs and biases visible by literalizing them into standardized rhetorical units. This first genre of #nohomo tweet underscores how same-sex sociability functions as a site of anxiety for the performance for straight masculinity.

Body Care, Personal Appearance, and Femininity as Queer

The second major trend in the usage of #nohomo is the frequency with which the hashtag appears in conjunction with tweets about body care

and personal appearance. As is the case in tweets regarding male-male intimacy, these tweets seem to come primarily from straight male users. Within the subjects of body care and personal appearance, physical fitness and clothing are both common themes. Here are three examples of this type of tweet:

I just finished my workout and my abs look sick.
#nohomo

I got my eyebrows done today. #nohomo

Can I wear a scarf with a button-down shirt or is that weird? #nohomo

Each of these three utterances represents a different aspect of this trend. The implications of the first tweet seem, at first glance, the most straightforward. Like the tweet above in which a user expresses admiration for Michael Phelps's muscles, the statement that the user's "abs look sick" ("sick" used in complimentary sense) is imagined to run the risk of seeming homoerotic; a male user appreciating a male body, even his own, triggers anxieties about sounding "homo." However, it is meaningful that the contents of this tweet also mark it as heteronormatively masculine. In boasting about the intensity of his workout and the resulting strength of his body, this user is simultaneously performing a version of straight male butchness as well as undermining that same identity performance by straying dangerously close to the queer. To say "no homo" after admiring his own body implies that this user thinks he looks so good that he might be attracted to himself. This is an example of a tweet in which #nohomo infuses utterances with queer implications even as it purports to disavow them.

By contrast, the second and third tweets in this list are less concerned with homoeroticism and more with normative gender expectations. In the tweet about having his eyebrows "done," the user employs #nohomo in order to preempt the response that it would be socially unacceptable for a straight man to take part in this kind of personal grooming, which is traditionally associated with women's body care practices. In this case, the "homo" in #nohomo seems synonymous with "effeminate," implying that disavowing queerness also means disavowing femininity. In the third tweet, the user asks whether he can wear a scarf with a button-down shirt. Though the question seems simple, the inclusion of #nohomo signals

that the users believes even this level of interest in clothing and personal appearance may be deemed unacceptable for a straight male subject. Here, #nohomo takes on a self-policing role; the user calls out and rejects the imagined queerness of his question, performing the task of cultural regulation on himself. Whereas the first genre of #nohomo tweets mediated intimacies between men, many tweets in this second grouping mediate the speaker's intimate relationship with his own body.

Strikingly, this genre of tweets, especially those that address body care and personal appearance, suggest that many of the conditions of "homo-ness" relate much more closely to gender than to sexuality or erotic desire. For a straight male subject, association with female-coded interests is seen as queer. Heterosexual masculinity, in such moments, defines itself in opposition to femininity. This is one of the key findings that this research reveals: that queerness, as constructed through a hegemonic system of beliefs, is imagined as fundamentally linked to the destabilization of normative gender roles. In this way among others, the imagined characteristics of queerness that #nohomo tweets suggest differ substantially from how LGBTQ subjects and queer theory have traditionally articulated their own identities. They also differ from the common definition of homosexuality (i.e., an orientation toward sex or romance with a person of the same sex), suggesting that #nohomo speaks to a more complex network of beliefs and concerns that operate beneath the surface in mainstream perceptions of LGBTQ people. It is also important that the site of gender anxiety for straight masculinity, as suggested by #nohomo usage, is the heterosexual male body. #nohomo is much less frequently used for female-coded activities (e.g., crafting, shopping) and much more frequently for a set of female-coded interactions with the embodied self. Far from representing a material stronghold of heteronormativity, the straight male body becomes a place of weakness. It is when discussing his body that the speaker must be most watchful and most self-correcting, lest discourse stray toward queer.

(Queer) Affect and Twitter as Women's Writing

The third main trend in #nohomo usage is the appearance of the hashtag in association with tweets from ostensibly straight male users in which they directly express emotion. Some of these tweets make reference to positive emotions, others to negative emotions; some reflect emotional responses to important life events, others speak to everyday experiences. Here are some examples of this genre of tweet:

I'm just feeling really sad today. #nohomo

Being a dad is the best, you guys. This little kid makes me so happy. #nohomo

I love you all! #nohomo

In the first tweet, the user describes feeling upset or depressed, whereas the speakers in the second two tweets are expressing feelings of affection and love. What these tweets share is that they reflect the belief that the admission of emotion is itself “homo,” regardless of the specificities of the sentiment expressed or the object of that sentiment. This genre of #nohomo tweet suggests that feeling itself is imagined as nonmasculine and therefore non-straight. Sadness and love alike fall outside the boundaries of acceptable male, heterosexual subjecthood; affect becomes queer. Straight masculinity on Twitter is therefore not only constructed through what a user may do but also explicitly through what (and whether) a user may feel. #nohomo here functions to mark affect as queer while simultaneously allowing users to return to heterosexual normativity after having expressed emotion.

Admittedly, this genre of tweets appears with considerably less frequency than those that relate to male-male intimacy or the male body. However, I include it here because these tweets highlight a commonality that exists across almost all types of #nohomo tweets: an imagined interrelation between feeling and queerness. In tweets about friendship and fandom, #nohomo mediates sentiments of warmth and love. Similarly, in tweets about body care and appearance, the function of #nohomo is to de-queer the act of *caring*. The user who worries that asking about his clothing choices will seem “homo” is less concerned with his clothing itself and more concerned that caring too much about clothing will mark him as queer; the user who reports having his eyebrows done employs #nohomo to ward off the implication that he cares more about his appearance than a straight man should. Being “homo,” in such instances, is not about doing or looking unacceptable but about feeling unacceptable. #nohomo itself is a unit of communication powered by the feeling of anxiety. It serves an affective function (rendering feeling un-queer) and reflects an affective state (fearing associations with queerness). Like straight male users’ own bodies, the user’s state as a feeling subject emerges as a site of slippage between heteronormativity and an imagined queerness.

This connection between queerness, affect, and identity reintroduces the importance of the Twitter platform itself into an analysis of #nohomo. “Homo-ness,” as a critique of the trends in #nohomo tweets has revealed, is closely linked to femininity and the expression of emotion. Twitter, too, is culturally associated with this same nexus of gender and emotion. Commonly described as a micro-blogging platform, Twitter emerges from a history of online, text-based self-expression platforms (e.g., LiveJournal) with its roots in predigital forms such as the written diary. Like public, short-form diary entries, tweets are commonly used to document or reflect on a user’s daily life. Genre historians have argued compellingly for the gendered history of the diary, long seen as women’s writing.⁷ In this way, Twitter and social media posting more generally can be understood in association with cultural constructs of femininity; simply using Twitter puts the straight male user in the realm of the feminine—which, by the logics of #nohomo, is queer. In this way, Twitter itself, as a platform, produces anxieties about queerness for heterosexual masculinity.

The prevalence of #nohomo on Twitter, then, can be explained by more than its easy translation to hashtag form. Social media sites of this sort promote self-reflection, emoting, and interpersonal connection. The “homo” is associated with intimacy and attention to the self, both of which Twitter fosters in its structures and its cultures. Understood in this way, it could be said that all tweets contain something of the queer that #nohomo seeks to disavow. For this reason, the widespread use of #nohomo on Twitter reflects not only a larger-scale social issue with homophobia and discrimination in digital spaces but also an unspoken belief that social media may itself be too feminine, too intimate, and too queer for straight male users who are attempting to successfully perform heteronormative masculinity. #nohomo mediates and self-polices identity in a way that is specific to the digital environment precisely because that environment raises a wealth of anxieties and concerns around gender, sexuality, and maintaining the normative self.

Networks of Disavowal and Not-Queer Twitter

What, ultimately, are the primary social and rhetorical functions of #nohomo? What is the discursive and cultural work being done by the hashtag? Some of its functions, notably those that seem intentional on the part of users, are in line with the oppressive and hegemonic values of homophobia. #nohomo works to uphold dominant notions of straight

masculinity. It mediates intimacy between men and renders acceptable an interest in the male body; it also allows for the expression of emotion, otherwise associated with queerness. At the same time, #nohomo demonstrates a number of functions that blur the line between homophobia and queer expression. It allows for straight male users to incorporate elements of perceived “homo-ness” into their otherwise normative self-presentations. Often it colors utterances that might otherwise appear to have no queer valence with homoerotic implications. The hashtag signals and simultaneously counterbalances the culturally coded queerness of the Twitter platform itself. Across these many functions, #nohomo reflects a set of heteronormative anxieties and beliefs about what constitutes straightness, in which straight masculinity is defined as the opposite of the “homo.” To be “homo” is not the same as to be gay in the way that gayness might be articulated by an LGBTQ subject. Rather, “homo-ness” is as much a matter of gender as of sexuality or desire. Being “homo” means falling outside accepted cultural norms for male heterosexuality and, in particular, in the ways that one expresses oneself in digital spaces. More than a tool for enacting discursive violence against LGBTQ subjects, #nohomo is a tool for the self-policing of straight masculinity. This vision of what is “homo” does not imagine queerness as a set of desires that the subject has but rather as something that might happen to the subject—something they might accidentally slip into.

In this way #nohomo does the work of establishing identity through disavowal; the straight is the not queer. The straight self is a self of disavowal. Because the nature of the hashtag is to create connections, #nohomo in fact establishes a network of this disavowal between tweets and users. This final function, the creation of a network of disavowal, is crucial for understanding the broader social implications of #nohomo on Twitter and beyond. #nohomo is fundamentally contradictory; it queers even as it negates the queer. The prevalence of #nohomo creates a “not queer” Twitter, a shadow network of things that are alike in refusing to be likened. In this way, in seeking to reject queerness, #nohomo makes visible a vast network of all of the things that cultural anxiety dictates may seem queer. It affiliates all those users who deploy #nohomo in order to reject affiliation with sexual and gender identities that fall outside the dictates of heteronormativity. Therefore, the network of disavowal functions on both a personal and a social level. On the level of the individual, it creates ties between #nohomo users, who form a kind of “uncommunity,” a disparate network of those who all wish to be unaffiliated with the same thing. On the cultural level, #nohomo reveals a network

of anxieties and beliefs that seek to disavow the thing that nonetheless shapes and binds them: queerness.

Hashtags and homophobia on social media represent a rich area of further research. Research of this sort is important in this moment when harassment campaigns and threats are making clear that there is no easy distinction between what happens in online spaces and what is “real.” As a long-standing fixture of Twitter’s discursive landscape, #nohomo reflects the discrimination and hate speech present on the platform, even as the site exists as a powerful tool for the fight against oppression—and, more specifically, even as this fight takes the form of other hashtags, like #BlackLivesMatter. Yet #nohomo does more than this; it also demonstrates how what people say and how they say it in online spaces is key to the construction and upholding of gender and sexual identity. At the same time, it demonstrates how nuanced, difficult, and at times contradictory the performances of these identities are—how much work is required in order to make oneself acceptable as a heteronormative subject within digital spaces that are coded or perceived as gendered or queer. Whether #nohomo enacts homophobia or allows for the expression of queerness (while upholding a normative system) is not ultimately the question; it does both. What becomes clear is that it is the hashtag, this unique linguistic unit, that is able to do the complexity of this work, revealing a vision of straight masculinity threatened by digital communication that requires digital tools to uphold it.

Notes

1. This number represents an average of the total “no homo” phrases tallied at NoHomophobes.com, a website that counts daily instances of homophobic speech on Twitter, as noted from late 2014 to early 2016.

2. One such online harassment campaign that illustrates the real-life stakes of both web-based violence and the networks formed by Twitter hashtagging is #GamerGate. Formed in 2014, a group of reactionary video gamers organizing under this hashtag has launched ongoing attacks against women, queer people, and people of color who push for diversity in games. These attacks received national attention through coverage in publications like the *New York Times*.

3. This distinction between algorithm and analysis matters because, as feminist scholars of the digital humanities like Jacque Wernimont (2016) and Roopika Risam (2015) have noted, data-driven initiatives often risk reinforcing hegemonic power structures by overlooking the politics of their “objective” methodologies.

4. See especially Butler’s *Excitable Speech: A Politics of the Performative* (1997),

the discussion of power in Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1995), and J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962).

5. According to the Pew Research Centers studies of social media user demographics, African American and Hispanic adults have consistently been somewhat more likely to use Twitter than white adults (28% of Black adults reported using Twitter in 2014, as compared to 20% of white adults, for example). However, white users are still in the majority on the site. Once again using 2014 as an example, the Pew Research Center reported that in that year approximately 85 percent of white adults used the internet, compared to 81 percent of Black adults and 83% of Hispanic adults. The United States Census Bureau estimates that in 2015, 77 percent of Americans were white. Together these numbers indicate that white users on Twitter outnumber Twitter users of color.

6. With the exception of tweets posted through private accounts, all of the user-generated content on Twitter is publicly available without password-protected access and is therefore considered acceptable for use in research without permission from users. However, in order to best illustrate the #nohomo usage patterns, all of the example tweets included here are reconstructed amalgams rather than verbatim quotes.

7. An example of scholarship that outlines the predigital link between gender, genre, and the diary is the introduction to Suzanne L. Bunkers and Cynthia Anne Huff's *Inscribing the Daily: Critical Essays on Women's Diaries* (1996).

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